

Third Sunday After Pentecost

Dominica Tertia Post Pentecosten

TLM propers: the endangered sinner sought, strengthened, and welcomed into joy

Proper	TLM text / reference	Scriptural axis	Connection
Introit	<i>Respice in me, et miserere mei</i> (Ps. 24:16, 18)	Solitude, poverty, mercy	The worshipper enters neither self-sufficient nor hidden: affliction and sin are placed under God's merciful gaze.
Collect	<i>Protector in te sperantium, Deus</i>	Providence and pilgrimage	God's mercy supplies what is neither strong nor holy without him and orders temporal goods toward eternity.
Epistle	1 Pet. 5:6–11	Humility, trust, vigilance	Casting care on God and resisting the devil are one movement of humble, active faith.
Gradual	<i>Iacta cogitatum tuum in Domino</i> (Ps. 54:23, 17, 19)	Entrusted anxiety and deliverance	Before the Gospel, the congregation practices entrusting the anxiety that makes isolation and despair attractive.
Alleluia	<i>Deus iudex iustus, fortis et pateriens</i> (Ps. 7:12)	Justice, strength, patience	Divine patience opens the Gospel's mercy without denying judgment.
Gospel	Luke 15:1–10	Sheep, drachma, repentance, joy	Christ answers proud murmuring by revealing the search for sinners and heaven's joy at their repentance.
Offertory	<i>Speret in te omnes</i> (Ps. 9:11–13)	Trust and the poor man's prayer	The found sinner becomes an offering Church that trusts, seeks, praises, and remembers the afflicted.
Secret	<i>Respice, Domine, munera supplicantis Ecclesiae ... et saluti credentium perpetua sanctificatione sumenda concede</i>	The Church's gifts and sanctification	The God whose merciful gaze seeks the lost is asked to look upon the Church's gifts and grant that continual sanctification make them serve the salvation of the faithful.
Communion	<i>Gaudium est Angelis Dei</i> (Luke 15:10)	Joy over repentance	The antiphon celebrates repentant restoration; Eucharistic joy does not erase the call to conversion or proper reception.
Postcommunion	<i>Sancta tua nos, Domine, sumpta vivificent</i>	Vivification and lasting mercy	The holy things received give life and prepare the purified faithful for everlasting mercy.
Sense	Synthesis		
Literal	Jesus receives publicans and sinners and answers the Pharisees' and scribes' murmuring with a shepherd and a woman who seek until they find; Peter commands humility, the casting of care on God, vigilance, and resistance in faith.		
Allegorical	Gregory reads the Shepherd as Christ bearing fallen humanity, and the woman and lamp as divine Wisdom manifested in the flesh to restore the Creator's likeness in man. The Church proclaims and sacramentally serves this saving work.		
Moral	Grace takes the initiative, yet the hearer is summoned to repent, humble himself, cast his cares on God, resist the devil, and exchange contempt at another's return for shared joy.		
Anagogical	The angels' joy and the Postcommunion's everlasting mercy direct present repentance toward the restored heavenly communion of angels and redeemed humanity.		

The Conversion of the Gaze

Reading key

This Mass changes not only the condition of the lost but the way loss is seen. The solitary sinner asks to come under God's merciful gaze; the devil watches for someone to devour; Christ searches; false justice looks down; and the angels behold repentance with joy. The question running through the propers is therefore: *whose sight will teach the worshipper to see?*

Five Ways of Seeing

Observer	Object	Manner of seeing	Spiritual result
God, invoked in the Introit	The solitary, poor, afflicted sinner	<i>Respice in me</i> : look upon me and have mercy	Need is made visible to mercy rather than hidden by self-sufficiency.
The prowling lion	The isolated and anxious Christian	Watchful appetite "seeking whom he may devour" (1 Pet. 5:8)	Isolation becomes danger; sobriety and resistance are necessary.
Shepherd and woman	Sheep outside the flock; coin hidden in the house	Patient search <i>until</i> each is found	Grace takes the initiative and restores what could not secure itself.
Pharisees and scribes	Christ receiving sinners	Murmuring comparison and disdain	Another's restoration is treated as an offense rather than a cause for joy.
Angels of God	One sinner repenting	Attention transfigured into shared delight	Communion gives the Church heaven's response to recovered life.

A patristic test for the gaze

St. Gregory the Great diagnoses the contrast in *Forty Gospel Homilies* 34: "True justice has compassion, while false justice has disdain." The sentence does not erase judgment; it distinguishes the just and patient Judge acclaimed in the Alleluia from the self-protective judgment of the murmurers.

How the Lost Are Found: Sheep and Coin

Feature	The sheep	The drachma	What the pairing teaches
Form of loss	Exposed outside the flock, vulnerable to danger	Hidden inside the house, its stamped image obscured	Sin can appear as estrangement or as a likeness present but no longer legible.
The seeker	The shepherd goes after the one	The woman lights a lamp and sweeps carefully	The same mercy acts personally and intelligently; neither search is casual.
Means of recovery	The sheep is placed on the shepherd's shoulders	The lamp reveals and the swept house yields the coin	Gregory reads the shoulders as Christ bearing fallen humanity, and the lamp as divine Wisdom shining through Christ's humanity.

Feature	The sheep	The drachma	What the pairing teaches
Restored place	Returned to companionship	Recovered within the ordered house	Salvation restores communion and also the Creator's image in the person.
Public result	Friends and neighbors are summoned	Friends and neighbors are summoned	Recovery is completed in shared joy, not private possession.
Human response	Luke explicitly names repentance	The recovered image must become recognizable in life	Grace's priority does not make the person inert; the Epistle still commands humility, vigilance, and resistance.

The value borne by the image

St. Ambrose, *Exposition of the Gospel of Luke* VII.211–212: “We are coins. Let us have a price. We are sons. Let us hurry to the Father.” Recovered dignity is gift and summons: the King's image gives the return both its possibility and its direction.

Grace and Response: A Braided Route Through the Mass

The two strands must remain joined. Read alone, the divine strand can be mistaken for human passivity; read alone, the human strand can be mistaken for self-rescue.

Liturgical moment	Divine initiative	Human and ecclesial response
Introit + Collect	God looks mercifully on poverty, protects those who hope in him, multiplies mercy, and orders temporal passage toward eternity.	The worshipper discloses affliction and sin, asks not to be abandoned, and consents to receive temporal goods as a pilgrim.
Epistle + Gradual	God cares for the humbled person and promises deliverance from affliction.	Care is cast upon God; the Gradual turns the apostolic command into sung entrustment, freeing the Christian for sobriety and resistance.
Alleluia + Gospel	The just, strong, patient Judge appears as Shepherd and incarnate Wisdom, searching until the lost is found.	Sinners draw near to hear and repent; the alternative response is the murmurer's refusal to rejoice.
Offertory + Secret	God knows those who seek him, remembers the cry of the poor, and receives the Church's gifts for salvation and perpetual sanctification.	The found person enters the supplicating Church: trusting, seeking, praising, remembering the afflicted, and offering a life still being made holy.
Communion + Postcommunion	Heaven rejoices over repentance; the holy things received give life and prepare the purified for everlasting mercy.	The communicant exchanges the murmurer's gaze for angelic joy and receives rescue as an enduring sacramental life.

At Mass: follow the change of viewpoint

Hear the Introit from inside exposed need; let the Gradual make the Epistle's surrender of care present; hold justice and patience together in the Alleluia; notice both searchers and murmurers in the Gospel; join the poor in the Offertory; and receive the Communion as heaven's schooling of earthly desire.

Discernment Pairs

Do not confuse	The distinction	Where the propers hold it together
Trust / passivity	Entrusting care removes the fantasy of total control, not the duty to remain sober and resist evil.	Epistle and Gradual join casting care to standing firm in faith.
Vigilance / despair	The lion is real, but it is not the only active figure in the Sunday; the Shepherd searches more deeply than the predator prowls.	Epistle and Gospel set spiritual danger inside prior and pursuing mercy.
Mercy / moral indifference	The joy concerns a sinner who repents, and the seeker is also the just Judge.	Alleluia supplies justice, strength, and patience immediately before Luke's parables.
Justice / disdain	True justice recognizes evil without using it to establish distance from the person being restored.	The murmurers' posture is contradicted by the Communion's angelic joy.
Being found / remaining inert	Recovery originates in the seeker, then matures into repentance, resistance, offering, sanctification, and praise.	Gospel, Offertory, Secret, and Postcommunion trace the restored person's continuing life.

Primary References

- *Missale Romanum* (1962), *Dominica Tertia post Pentecosten*; local OCR temporal corpus, lines for the Third Sunday after Pentecost. Latin OCR remains to be checked against a printed missal before publication.
- St. Gregory the Great, *Forty Gospel Homilies*, Homily 34, excerpts on Luke 15, linked working English text.
- St. Ambrose, *Exposition of the Gospel of Luke* VII.211–212, linked working English excerpt.